

OMICRON-ED
Patients at the Covid care facility in CWG village, Delhi

KAMAL KISHORE/PTI

around half the negative results could be false. Another study in Maharashtra by the ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research) found that 34 per cent of RAT results were false negatives. "Timely diagnosis is needed," says Dr Puneet Khanna, head of respiratory medicine at Manipal Hospitals. "Not only to ensure the correct line of treatment to follow but also to break the chain of transmission. An antigen test must be followed with RT-PCR for confirmation."

It is also absolutely essential to consult a doctor as soon as one tests positive. "Self-medication, even for mild cases, is not recommended," says Dr Farah Ingale, an internal medicine specialist from Mumbai. "A lot of parameters need to be considered when treating Covid. Just because a certain treatment is working for others or is in the news does not mean it will automatically work for you. Elderly patients or those with comorbidities, in particular, should take extra caution and follow up with doctors during and post Covid." Rest, a light diet and symptom-specific medication are the best bet to fight off Covid-19.

The MoHFW has now revised its Covid management guidelines issued in September 2021. It has taken two drugs—hydroxychloroquine and ivermectin—off the list. Patients with mild symptoms are advised just paracetamol to manage fever. Inhaling Budesonide is recommended if symptoms persist beyond five days. For moderate to severe patients, the categorisation of which depends on the patient's oxygen level and state of consciousness, the guidelines recommend the use of steroids, remdesivir and tocilizumab. And though monoclonal antibodies do not feature on the list, the demand for them is growing, as it is for other, newer forms of treatment (see *New Lines of Treatment*).

However, doctors warn against the indiscriminate use of newer drugs or self-medication. "With Covid, there is no one-drug-fits-all solution because the symptoms and progression of disease are different for different people, and now, also different for different variants," says Dr Rahul Pandit, director of ICU at Fortis Hospitals, Mumbai, and a member of the state task force on Covid-19. "It is absolutely important that medicine be taken in consultation with doctors and at the right time." The timing of the medicine, in particular, is proving to be crucial. In the last wave, for example, the indiscriminate use of steroids in the first week of symptoms (also known as the viral replication phase) actually contributed towards increasing the severity of the disease. Mucormycosis or Black Fungus was also a common side-effect of steroid use. "Our treatment for Covid-19 has advanced significantly in the past year," says Dr Vivek Nangia, head of pulmonology at Max Saket. "But Omicron is a new variant and we are still understanding how different drugs will work. For that reason, we are being cautious in the use of medicine, including antibody cocktails."

HOW LONG IS THE OMICRON WAVE EXPECTED TO LAST?

The government-backed Sutra, a mathematical model to track Covid spread in India, predicts that the third wave will peak at the end of the month with 400,000-800,000 new cases a day. Cities like Delhi and Mumbai will have 50,000-60,000 new cases daily. The model also predicts that the wave will decline sharply in February and end by March.

The experience in other countries is similar. It took